New Delhi did not see any reason why he should hand over power.[82] In what he remembers as an especially unpleasant and acrimonious exchange, Srinivasan viewed Hurd's argument (of pressuring the head of government of another country to step down) as 'preposterous'.[83] India's preference for Rabbani over Hekmatyar reflected the ongoing tension between Rao's officially conciliatory approaches and the thriving anti-Pakistan partisanship among policymakers. Having become increasingly comfortable with Massoud and his associates, Indian policymakers did not want to risk another exploratory round of dealing with and subsequently cultivating Hekmatyar in a constantly changing conflict environment. London and New Delhi's positions on Afghanistan, thus, were just as far apart in the 1990s, as they had been in the 1980s, and as they remained throughout the US-led war after the 9/11 attacks.

The Taliban's emergence in October 1994 plunged Mestiri's mission into total disarray.[84] Moving towards Kabul at a spectacular pace and having defeated *Hizb-e-Islami* and *Hizb-e-Wahdat*, the power balance in Afghanistan hung between the Taliban on one side and the Rabbani government in Kabul with Ismael Khan in Herat and Dostum in Mazar-e-Sharif on the other in 1995. Instead of changing tack, given the evolving situation, Mestiri stuck to his transition plan and sought a ceasefire followed by elections. Rabbani stalled the plan, making Mestiri's mission irrelevant. Not surprisingly, in a speech at a donor conference in Stockholm in June 1995, Mestiri denounced the 'Rabbani government as an illegitimate faction dominated by Tajiks'.[85] Mestiri was particularly wary of Moscow's efforts to build a Massoud-Dostum alliance in the face of the Taliban and thought that this could be 'quite damaging to the peace process'. In the same speech, he proposed that the UN and international community should challenge 'the legitimacy of those who claim to be in power [Massoud-Rabbani]'.[86] The UN held Rabbani responsible for undermining its peace plan at various points in time, but mostly in the latter half of 1995 just before and after the fall of Herat.[87]

Similar to then Pakistan's PM Benazir Bhutto's denunciation of the Rabbani government as 'illegitimate' in early 1995, Mestiri's statement did not cut ice with New Delhi. Having reopened its Kabul mission in May 1995 after a period of forced closure, the official Indian view became grimmer. The MEA noted: